

# Secularism and Christianity: *Caritas* in the Thought of Gianni Vattimo and Pope Benedict XVI

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## Introduction

In the aftermath of the fall of the Iron Curtain that had divided Europe for a generation, with the subsequent accession of former Eastern Bloc countries to the European Union and the drastic changes within the demographics of Western Europe, Europe has witnessed an unparalleled intensity of debates about its own identity. The question of religion and its role in modern, secular European societies has emerged as a virtually ubiquitous component of these debates. Although the renewed controversy about the role of religion in European public life is a multi-layered and complex phenomenon, the discussions inevitably allude, often implicitly, to the function of Christianity in the construal of European identities.

The following investigation will explore two competing interpretations of the secular in Europe, examining them through corresponding articulations of the meaning of Christian *caritas*. The first view, represented by the hermeneutical postmodernism of Gianni Vattimo, proposes an understanding of Christian *caritas* as a universal condition for the flourishing of difference in an irreducibly plural world. In Vattimo's thought, Christian *caritas* is no longer founded on Christianity's particular claims for truth, but is understood as an expression of a Christianity unfettered from all ties to epistemological foundations.<sup>1</sup> In contrast to Vattimo's radical antifoundationalism, Pope Benedict XVI's understanding of *caritas* is founded on the particularity of Christian truth. This truth, however, is not restricted to the Christian *ecclesia*. The latter makes it universally accessible through its evangelical mission.<sup>2</sup>

These divergent visions of the contemporary meaning and role of Christian *caritas* are aligned with equally contrasting roles attributed to Christianity in

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KORNEL ZATHURECZKY is Assistant Professor, Religious Studies Department, St. Francis Xavier University, Antigonish, Nova Scotia.

contemporary European reality. On the one hand, Vattimo proposes a weak Christianity with no metaphysical aspirations and certainly no urges to claim for itself the designation *vera religio*, the true religion. On the other hand, Benedict advocates an understanding of Christianity which recovers what he considers Christianity's original and distinctive character: Christianity as *vera religio*.<sup>3</sup> For Vattimo, peaceful coexistence and flourishing in a multicultural society is predicated upon Christian *caritas* without the claims of Christian truth, while for Benedict Christian *caritas* is the manifestation of the universal truth of Christianity. The context of these two, diametrically opposed visions of the relationship between Christianity and Europe is a political-cultural situation in which Europe is facing new challenges, a pre-eminent one being the challenge of Islam to the secular foundations of modern European democracies.

## Two Views of Contemporary Europe

### Europe: The End of Modernity

The discomfort about the public resurgence of religion in the European context brings to light the problematic enterprise of privileging an understanding of modernity in the European context which defines it as the ultimate triumph of scientific rationality and the definitive overcoming of religion in contemporary society. A purely scientific rationality as exemplified in positivism, and the technological society envisioned and realized by it have, however, led to new anomalies regarding the nature of reason, raising questions about its manner of overcoming religion.

The crisis of modernity, modernity understood here as the faith in the powers of reason to facilitate the unhindered progress of science through history, has found expression through two philosophical announcements, respectively signalling the end of an epoch and the concomitant challenge to find new ways of orientation in the world. The first announcement is made by Nietzsche who, standing on the seemingly solid ground of modernity, relays the news of the death of God. The second is Heidegger's announcement of the overcoming (*Verwindung*) of the traditional metaphysical concept of Being.<sup>4</sup> The force of *Verwindung* is such that it wholly and completely unmoors metaphysics from the heavy ontological weight of Being.

Neither announcement is to be considered objectively descriptive. They do not correspond to ontological states of affairs,<sup>5</sup> nor do they mirror a new kind of reality, or point to a new epistemology. Rather, one simply receives them, as revelations without divinity, hearing in them the "noise" associated with the event of the end of modernity. The very announcement of the passing of an epoch, the epoch of Being, precipitates this passing, without ushering in or constituting the advent of a new foundation. One can see that there can be no ultimate confirmation for the end of modernity, which is closely allied with the metaphysics of Being. There are, however, incontrovertible signs of its happening.

## Triumph of Pluralism or Crisis of Relativism?

*Gianni Vattimo*

Nietzsche's announcement of the death of God, far from being a metaphysical assertion, implies the passing of the moral God, that is, the God of metaphysics, a God who continued to haunt the landscape of modern Europe even in his absence. A post-metaphysical Europe that left behind the absolutist claims of reason and the corresponding image of a God of infinite attributes can also mean, however, the appearance of new mythologies and new gods. This novel situation signals, in Vattimo's view, the possibility of the return to belief as a Christian, or at least to a belief in belief, to which corresponds a God no longer situated in the constricting matrix of onto-theology but in whom it is possible to believe in the world of difference, a possibility which, however, is no longer supported by ultimate foundations.

Ultimately, for Vattimo, the secularism of Europe represents the fulfillment of Christianity, the ultimate realization of the Christian kerygma. If this perception of the connection between Christianity and Europe is true, then any effort to reclaim Christianity for Europe as an ontologically stable foundation of the latter is wishful thinking at best, and a futile exercise at worst. Paradoxically, Christianity is "present" as the truth of secular Europe, whether this is explicitly acknowledged or not, a Europe released from the constraints of metaphysical foundations.

The truth of Christianity lies in its own weakening which manifests itself in the atrophy of European hegemony. Christianity's truth is revealed with the disintegration of European supremacy, with the end of Europe as the centre of power, as the driving force of universal history. The process of weakening of post-Shoah and post-colonial Europe cannot be reversed by elusive attempts to retrieve a strong Christian foundation. Only through the ultimate deconstruction of the Self as European, or the exclusively European self, can Christianity realize its universal mission to be comprehensively inclusive. This unqualified and unequivocal inclusiveness finds tangible and audible expression through the emergence of an open space, where previously unheard voices join in the proliferation of interpretations.<sup>6</sup> The announcements of the death of God and of the end of metaphysics presage the commencement of the adventures in difference, the arrival of a reality which is irreducibly plural.<sup>7</sup>

In Vattimo's "weak thought" the reign of universal reason and its role in providing epistemological foundations is replaced by the universalism of hermeneutics. There is no longer an objective reality that reason can scrutinize. The real world has been turned into a fable and the new form of objectivity that has emerged is based on "intersubjective linguistic consensus."<sup>8</sup>

Philosophy as hermeneutics represents the dissolution of the stable ontological structures of Being and the radical unfolding of the event-like character of Being. Vattimo sees in the radicality of the hermeneutical project, in that it empties Being of its metaphysical foundations, the realization, if not the fulfill-

ment, of the Christian understanding of the kenosis of God through the incarnation of the Son. The post-metaphysical epoch, represented by the radical hermeneuticity of reality, reality understood as a message, is "the development and maturation of the Christian message."<sup>9</sup>

Christianity's message of the kenosis of God is finally and fully realized in the post-metaphysical world, where "secularization has become the norm for all theological discourse."<sup>10</sup> It is within this secular milieu that Christianity finally makes sense in that it no longer corresponds to "the world of things at hand (*vorhanden*), objectively present."<sup>11</sup> Reason is no longer needed to demonstrate the truth of Christianity but finds itself transformed, through the universalization of Christic kenosis, as an edifying tool in facilitating the proliferation and mutual enrichment of interpretations, through dialogue, where reason is essentially an arbiter between interpretive options.<sup>12</sup>

### *Pope Benedict XVI*

In comparison to Vattimo's postmodern recapturing of the non-absolute truth of Christianity, Pope Benedict XVI offers a drastically different assessment of secular Europe and its connections with Christianity.

In his diagnosis of the apparent malady of the collective European psyche, Benedict perceives the symptom of secular Europe's identity crisis in the ever-spreading germ of relativism. While Vattimo experiences the postmodern as a deliverance from the "Cartesian Anxiety" for ultimate foundations that has plagued European philosophy, Pope Benedict perceives this act of deliverance as an exorcism that has unleashed the plague of moral relativism.

Benedict links the current climate of moral relativism to the detrimental effects of positivism. Positivism led to the compartmentalization of reason which in turn redefined reason itself. Scientific rationality ended up being drastically distinguished from ethical and religious reasoning, claiming superiority over these domains. The realms of ethics and of religious beliefs now found themselves beyond the standards of rationality determined by science.

Benedict's concern regarding the reign of relativism in Europe is principally fuelled by his personal experiences in Nazi Germany.<sup>13</sup> He perceives the atrocities committed by Nazi Germany as unquestionably rooted in the emergence of a political system cut off from ultimate moral foundations, foundations he sees as being secured by Christianity. It is against this personal, historical backdrop that one can see why he so vehemently castigates relativism, which he perceives as ultimately detrimental to the dignity of human beings, a dignity accorded to humans on account of being created in the image of God. Moral relativism for Benedict ultimately culminates in the dissolution of societal accountability and, as his own painful personal experience demonstrates, can lead to unprecedented violence.

In his recent speech at the University of Regensburg, an academic discourse that gained notoriety because of an awkward, and perhaps unnecessary, refer-

ence to Islam, Benedict made an appeal to Christianity's fundamental commitment to reason, a commitment in which he sees the ultimate guarantee for non-violence.<sup>14</sup>

In his academic discourse in Regensburg, Benedict turns his attention to the Logos doctrine, an important achievement of the theology of the early Church which identifies the Incarnate Son of God as the incarnation of the pre-existent Logos. In the doctrine of the pre-existent Son, Christianity consciously engaged itself in the metaphysical tradition of Greek philosophy; yet, by wedding the Logos to the foundational Christian doctrine of the Incarnation, it also drastically reinvisioned the Greek metaphysical tradition. The impersonal Logos, or primordial reason that infuses the cosmos, is now identified with the Eternal Son of God who, through his incarnation, reconciles the created order to participation in the divine life.

Christianity, claims the pope, is by no means the rule of unreason and unintelligibility. If this were the case, then there would be serious consequences affecting the identity of the Christian God. God acting contrary to reason would be a God who would not be immune to caprice, a God perhaps similar to the gods depicted by Homer. Belief in a whimsical God, a God whose will remains inscrutable to reason, a God who may act against reason, is linked to the possibility for a religious sanctioning of violence.

In the Logos doctrine Pope Benedict sees not only a guarantee for a non-violent theology and political practice but also an equally important assurance that reason does not degenerate into instrumental reason.

The Logos doctrine of the patristic era conceives reason not as an abstraction but as essentially embodied. It is this embodied reason which in Benedict's estimation can withstand efforts of the instrumentalizing tendencies of modern technology and of global capitalism. The logic of global capitalism, under the guise of pluralism, relativizes the value of embodied life by absorbing it into the grand equation of the global capitalist network. In facing the challenges of life in the infinite fragmentation and multiplicity of the postmodern world Benedict turns to retrieve what he considers the absolute claim of Christianity for truth. At a moment of crisis, Christianity, through the doctrine of the incarnate Logos, provides the necessary emergency measures.

To many, however, Benedict's pronouncements are manifestations of an anachronistic view of Christianity. In espousing anew the universality of the truth of Christianity, Benedict is widely perceived as preaching a new message of intolerance.

The charge of intolerance levelled against Christianity is not a novel invention of its antagonists but one with which the Roman state confronted the new religion. Benedict, in his exploration of the roots of this accusation against Christianity, turns to Augustine's discussion of the thought of the Roman philosopher Varro on religion and its place in the life of the state.<sup>15</sup> Varro differentiates between three types of theologies: mythical theology, civil theology, and natural theology. Augustine, after discussing Varro's typology, classifies

Christianity as physical theology, that is, as a rationalist philosophy in distinction from approaches to religion either focusing on myths—the domain of mythical theology—or on the gods, invented by the state for the safekeeping of its own political power—the domain of civil theology. Viewed in this context, Christianity functions fundamentally as a force of demythologization, which offers a reasonable doctrine of God. In Augustine's scheme, one reiterated by Benedict, Christianity is ultimately founded upon knowledge and truth.

The universalism of Christianity, its universal message and its mission to share this message, is undergirded by its fundamental commitment to universal reason. In Benedict's reading it is because of this commitment to reason, and the proposed harmony between faith and reason, that the Romans labelled Christianity an atheistic cult, and as such, an enemy of the state. Christianity is the triumph of demythologization whose arrival makes all myth-based and state-sponsored religions superfluous.

Significantly, however, Christianity also distinguished itself from what Varro's scheme designated as natural theology, where God was understood as the soul of the cosmos. Christianity evaded this identification and, by its understanding of the world as a created cosmos, made an important distinction between the world and God. Thus, the ultimate principle that guarantees that religion is reasonable, and not the invention of the state, lies in the coming of God into the historical reality of human beings, through the incarnate Logos. It is ultimately in the Logos doctrine of Christianity where Benedict perceives the ineluctable rationality of Christianity and its universal apology to be *vera religio*, the true religion.

### Belief in Europe: The End of the Church as Institution

In Vattimo's eyes, and here his divergence from Pope Benedict is the most palpable, embracing the idea of a universal Logos to buttress the moral commitments of the Church implicates the teachings of the Church in the violence associated with traditional metaphysics. Ultimately, the ethical teachings of the Church, most glaringly its teachings regarding human sexuality, are clearly based on the violent foundations of metaphysics.

Vattimo looks at the Church, qua institution, as a relic from the past, an anachronistic entity still captivated by the false security of metaphysical foundationalism. The weak belief that suits the post-metaphysical epoch is the active nihilism that draws its energies from the announcements of Nietzsche and Heidegger. The *dépassement* of metaphysics corresponds to the *dépassement* of the Church understood as an institution based on authority, exemplified by the rigid hierarchy of the Roman Catholic Church.<sup>16</sup> Weak belief transpires in a Church without ecclesiastical authority. In contrast to the religiously tone-deaf anticlericalism of Richard Rorty, Vattimo's "weak thought" is an expression of an anticlericalism with the religious musicality of weak belief.<sup>17</sup>

The possibility for belief arises with the weakening of the institutional structure of the Church. One comes to belief no longer as a result of confronting the message of the gospel uniquely represented by the Church but, rather, by encountering the message of the gospel at the very basic levels of one's secular existence. Liberation means reading the gospel for oneself and resisting abdicating the responsibility of reading to religious institutions.

The post-metaphysical epoch is correlated with Joachim Fiore's third age of the spirit where Vattimo announces the paradox of the secular age as the spiritualization of Christianity.<sup>18</sup> Christianity leaves behind its institutional entrapments and with them all its attachments to worldly configurations of redemption. The end of modernity, the arrival of the postmodern, is simultaneously the universalization of the Christian message, a message whose vehicle is the secular.

Vattimo's conception of reason, truth and belief as post-institutional stands in stark contrast to Benedict's construction of these concepts. Benedict, in his apologetics for the lasting merits of Christianity as the guarantor of the right use of reason, embraces an understanding of reason which has a universal scope. Within such an understanding of reason the moral teachings of the Church are not merely pronouncements of a community but they also accede to universal significance.

The appeal to the lasting role of the Christian Church in Benedict's defence of reason is not a self-serving apology for the perpetuation of an institution many find anachronistic in the contemporary world. The Church as an institution differs from other, human, institutions in that it is divinely instituted and is the visible and lasting sign of God's kenotic love. It is a manifestation of the love of God, or rather of God as love, open to all to participate in. It offers the reality of God's participating love to the world. As an institution of a different order, one instituted by God as an objective sign of his love for the world, it plays a vital role in the criticism, even judgment, of worldly institutions and structures.

## *Caritas* in Europe

### The Inclusive Space of Pluralism

In Vattimo's scheme the weakening of Christianity, the dissipation of its influence in public life, is the manifestation of the truth of Christianity. The reality of secularism is the work of Christianity, whose truth lies in its kenotic self-emptying. The space of the secular, the space without ultimate ontological structures, the space of *différance*, is the space that is brought about by the kenotic self-emptying of God. This space is that of receptivity, inclusivity and hospitality.

Europe, in its identity of secularity, has come to manifest the ultimate message of the incarnation of Christ—kenotic love. European identity, being receptive to the announcement of the death of God, is no longer rooted in the violent foundations of a metaphysical Christianity but, by releasing itself from the

moorings of the moral law of absolute truths, it exhibits the boundless freedom of Christian *caritas*. Pluralism, where no one discourse can claim universal validity over the rest, therefore, does not represent the overcoming or debunking of Christianity but, rather, the emergence of a Christianity without absolutes, the truth of which no longer lies in universally valid claims but rather in the event of the universal inclusion of all human discourses. This does not mean that they are absorbed into one universal Christian discourse but that the possibility of their being heard is the result of the open space brought about by the kenosis of the Son. For Vattimo, the announcement of the death of God, the end of metaphysics, is an event of clearing, of kenosis, the universalization of the event of the Son's incarnation.<sup>19</sup>

Ultimately, what is left behind after the deconstruction of Christianity in the post-metaphysical epoch is the truth of Christianity, not expressed through propositions asserting claims for truth, but manifested in the universalism of *caritas*. According to Vattimo, it is in the manifestation of *caritas*, which does not function as a norm in the sense of metaphysical absolute but rather as a basic orientation toward others within the public sphere, that Christianity ultimately expresses itself as the final overcoming of violence.

When Vattimo is appropriating the Girardian insight about the religious origin of violence and its ultimate exposure through the gospel narrative, he does not believe that the institutional Church plays a fundamental and universal role in the realization and fulfillment of the truth of kenosis. In Vattimo's thought, the narrative memory of God's kenotic love is no longer institutionalized but somehow disseminated in the cultural memory of Europe. It is clear, through his confessed antipathies toward communitarian thought, that Vattimo does not envision the possibility of new communities being forged through some level of adherence to a shared narrative. Weak belief is the private affair of someone who participates in the weak ontology of the event of Being.

### Agape: The Fulfillment of Eros: Participating in God

In the first encyclical of his papacy, entitled *Deus Caritas Est*, it is to the notoriously elusive and hackneyed concept of love that Benedict turns his attention.<sup>20</sup> In light of the proliferation of usages of "love," can Christianity, a religion that explicitly identifies God as Love, say something distinctive about love? Perhaps the proliferation of semantic associations pertaining to love was an unconscious reaction to the Christian naming of God as Love, a kind of overdetermination of love, which was perceived as the erasure of the meaning of *eros* and the superimposition of a love unattached to the passions and desires of human beings. This is a speculation Benedict does not accept. Christianity, avers Benedict, is not the contamination of love understood as *eros* (Nietzsche's famous view), *eros* originally conceived in Greek mythology as the ecstatic relationship to the divine. Instead of being the defilement of *eros*, Christianity is its veritable purification. The purification of *eros* is not to be understood as a growing



disdain for the body, a common accusation levelled against Christianity, but rather as a resistance to the commodification and instrumentalization of the *corps humaine*.<sup>21</sup> The Christian usage of *eros* does not reduce the materiality of the body as expressed in human sexuality to the mere biological but affirms the integral character of materiality within the life of human beings.

Benedict's treatise on love follows a clear pattern in that, from a quite amorphous and diffuse sense of love, exhibited in the *ecstasis* of the self, he arrives at a more focused sense of love, culminating in the New Testament use of *agape*. *Agape* is not disconnected from *eros*, neither does it represent the poisoning of *eros* à la Nietzsche. *Agape* preserves *eros*' ecstatic character in the sense that it is described as the exodus of the narcissistic self in its journey of self-discovery through its self-giving and self-investment through other selves. It is through this *ecstasis* of the self, its kenosis (to use the key concept in Vattimo's evaluation of Christianity) that one arrives at the knowledge of God. "Love is indeed 'ecstasy,' not in the sense of a moment of intoxication, but rather as a journey, an ongoing exodus out of the closed inward-looking self towards its liberation through self-giving, and thus towards authentic self-discovery and indeed the discovery of God."<sup>22</sup>

Instead of perpetuating the modern disconnect between *eros* and *agape*, ascending and descending love, Benedict emphasizes the inseparability and ultimate unity of these two. The ecstatic desire of *eros* is purified and sustained by the love of God, *agape*, which itself finds ecstatic expression as *eros*, through the self-emptying of the Son. Therefore the love God is equally *eros* and *agape*. The erotic love of God for Creation finds ultimate expression in a bodily form, through the incarnate Son of God.

By identifying the Incarnate Son as the incarnation of the pre-existent Logos, Christianity effected a veritable revolution in both philosophy and the history of religions. Religion is not disconnected from reason (see Varro's categories above) but is its embodiment. Moreover, this connection between reason and faith is conceived as the kenotic self-giving of God who in his erotic ecstasy reunites his creation to himself. Put in Benedict's own words, "The philosophical dimension to be noted in this biblical vision, and its importance from the standpoint of the history of religions, lies in the fact that on the one hand we find ourselves before a strictly metaphysical image of God: God is the absolute and ultimate source of all being; but this universal principle of creation—the *Logos*, primordial reason—is at the same time a lover with all the passion of a true love."<sup>23</sup>

## Conclusion

For Benedict the universalism of Christianity is not a question of power, which indiscriminately enforces a master narrative on a universal audience. Christianity is not defined by a will to coerce, but by its message that it believes is necessary for the good of all. Benedict's particular strategy of aligning Christianity

with Europe, however, is a double-edged sword. In his grand narrative of the formation of Europe he is deafeningly silent about the experiences of many in history who encountered Christianity as an expression of power and coercion, through the colonizing efforts of European powers, never encountering God's ecstatic love as described by Benedict. The questions of many remain unanswered: Can Christianity simply extricate itself from its history of violence? Is there a Christianity which is different from its own history?

Benedict's apprehensions regarding the detrimental effects of secularism that threaten the future of Europe stand in huge contrast to Vattimo's almost perverse fascination with the fragility of secular European identities. The proliferation of subcultures and the emergence of decentralized identities, however, have not been able to effectively guide the lives of multitudes on the Old Continent and have become especially ineffectual in the reception of the influx of masses received by post-colonial and post-industrial Europe. The weak ontology of postmodern secular social reality has a particularly difficult time with the re-emergence of religious identities represented by Muslim citizens of Europe. The public visibility of these identities is especially disturbing to the secular identity of Europe where religion has been carefully kept out of the public square.

The thought of both Vattimo and Benedict transpires in the political-cultural sphere which is experiencing the so-called return of religion.<sup>24</sup> The alleged return of religion in the West is the re-emergence of a suppressed dimension of existence which manifests itself while the power of its suppressor, reason, is losing its firm grip on steering the West through the challenges of history. Reason defined by science is proving to be impotent in providing solutions to the ever-increasing complexity of challenges that faces the peaceful coexistence of humans. The return of religion is really not a return on a grand scale. It is rather a re-emergence, a reappearance of traces of religion. The manifestation of religion is the packaging of these traces into digestible commodities. What Vattimo misses in his philosophy of weak thought is the above conceptualization of the return of religion as it transpires in a society of mass media and communication. In terms of the thought of Benedict one can perceive a shift from the papacy of John Paul II in Benedict's realization of the meaning of the religious trace as an impotent force in withstanding the universalism of a form of life where all things come with a sales tag. Where John Paul thrived as a masterful manipulator of the mass media Benedict stumbles and stutters, but perhaps because of this ineptitude he may be best prepared to become the system's most potent critic.

## Notes

- 1 Gianni Vattimo, *Belief* (Stanford, CT: Stanford University Press, 1999), 62–65. Vattimo understands *caritas* as a guiding principle rather than a foundation of the infinite play of interpretations.
- 2 Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger, *Values in a Time of Upheaval* (New York, NY: Crossroad, 2006). Here Ratzinger (now Pope Benedict XVI) reiterates that Christian universalism is not driven by ambitions for power. Its universalism lies in its duty to disseminate knowledge for the common good.

- 3 See Joseph Ratzinger, *Truth and Tolerance: Christian Belief and World Religions* (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius, 2004), 162–183. For an interesting discussion on the background of *vera religio* see Serge Margel, *Superstition. L'anthropologie du religieux en terre de chrétienté* (Paris: Édition Galilée, 2005), 36–100.
- 4 On the use of *Verwindung* in Heidegger's work see Vattimo, *The End of Modernity* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1991), chap. 10.
- 5 Gianni Vattimo, *After Christianity* (New York, NY: Columbia University Press, 2002), 3–4.
- 6 This open space of inclusion is predicated on a shift within the self-understanding of Christianity which conceives itself no longer as the universal religion but as the religion of hospitality. Vattimo, *Belief*, 100–101.
- 7 "... it is precisely the Babelic world of late modernity that 'verifies' the Nietzschean announcement of the death of God and the Heideggerian announcement of the end of metaphysics...." Vattimo, *After Christianity*, 15.
- 8 See Richard Rorty and Gianni Vattimo *The Future of Religion* (New York, NY: Columbia University Press, 2005), 4.
- 9 Rorty and Vattimo, *The Future of Religion*, 47–49.
- 10 Santiago Zabala, "A Religion without Theists and Atheists" in Rorty and Vattimo, *The Future of Religion*, 2.
- 11 Rorty and Vattimo, *The Future of Religion*, 49.
- 12 Gianni Vattimo and Santiago Zabala, "Weak Thought and the Reduction of Violence" in *Common Knowledge* 8, 3 (2002): 452–463.
- 13 On Benedict's evaluation of Nazi ideology see his *Salt of the Earth: The Church at the End of Millennium. An Interview with Peter Seewald* (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius, 1997).
- 14 For the English version of Benedict's speech at the University of Regensburg see the internet site of the Holy See, [http://www.vatican.va/holy\\_father/benedict\\_xvi/speeches/2006/september/documents/hf\\_ben-xvi\\_spe\\_20060912\\_university-regensburg\\_en.html](http://www.vatican.va/holy_father/benedict_xvi/speeches/2006/september/documents/hf_ben-xvi_spe_20060912_university-regensburg_en.html). Last accessed September 2, 2008.
- 15 See Ratzinger's reference to Varro in *Truth and Tolerance: Christian Belief and World Religions* (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius, 2004), 165–169. Also see Augustine's discussion of Varro in his *City of God*, Book VI, chapters 4–8. St. Augustine, *The City of God*, translated by Henry Bettenson (London: Penguin, 1972).
- 16 For a discussion of Christianity's *dépassement* understood as its *auto-dépassement* see Jean-Luc Nancy, *La Déclosion (Déconstruction du christianisme)* (Paris: Édition Galilée, 2005), 203–226.
- 17 Rorty defines his anticlericalism in the following fashion: "It is the view that ecclesiastical institutions, despite all the good they do—despite all the comfort they provide to those in need or in despair—are dangerous to the health of democratic societies." Rorty and Vattimo, *The Future of Religion*, 33.
- 18 For Vattimo's reception of Joachim of Fiore see chapter 2 in *After Christianity*.
- 19 For Vattimo's understanding of kenosis see his *Belief*, 58–65.
- 20 Pope Benedict XVI, *God is Love: Deus Caritas Est* (San Francisco, CA: Ignatius, 2006).
- 21 See *Deus Caritas Est*: "Nowadays Christianity of the past is often criticized as having been opposed to the body; and it is quite true that tendencies of this sort have always existed. Yet the contemporary way of exalting the body is deceptive. *Eros*, reduced to pure 'sex,' has become a commodity, a mere 'thing' to be bought and sold, or rather, man himself becomes a commodity. This is hardly man's great 'yes' to the body. On the contrary, he now considers his body and his sexuality as the purely material part of himself, to be used and exploited at will."
- 22 Ibid.
- 23 Ibid.
- 24 On the return of religion theme see Marcel Gauchet, *The Disenchantment of the World* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1999); Margel, *Superstition*; Nancy, *La Déclosion*.